MONTHLY UPDATE

East Africa: monthly update, September – October 2026

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> *Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.*

PROGRESS

INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES
Regional collaboration

INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION
Standards · AI

SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE
Cybersecurity · Data Exchange · Digital Payments and Fintech · Sectoral management information systems · National statistics

CAPACITY AND INCLUSION
Training and skills

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

REGIONAL EDUCATION CONFERENCE ON MEASURABLE LEARNING OUTCOMES

- **ADEA pushes for measurable learning outcomes at the second EAC Regional Education Conference** — Association for the Development of Education in Africa (ADEA), 3 September 2026

  The second East African Community Regional Education Conference, held in Nairobi in August 2026, focused on measurable learning outcomes, according to the Association for the Development of Education in Africa. Somalia's education ministry described a public teacher attendance system that now feeds foundational learning data, with plans to extend it to national assessments.

IGAD TREATY 2023

- **Communique of the 74th Extraordinary Session of the IGAD Council of Ministers** — IGAD, 15 September 2026

  The IGAD Council of Ministers, meeting in Djibouti on 15 September 2026, endorsed in principle an IGAD Artificial Intelligence Centre of Excellence and invited member states to bid to host it. The council also recorded that five of seven members — Djibouti, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia and South Sudan — have ratified the 2023 IGAD Treaty, meeting the threshold for its entry into force.

COMESA IDEA PROGRAMME (INCLUSIVE DIGITALISATION IN EASTERN AND SOUTHERN AFRICA)

- **IDEA Half-Year Implementation Progress Report: January-June 2026 and Outlook for July-December 2026** — COMESA Secretariat (IDEA project), 1 October 2026 ANGOLA DRC MALAWI ZAMBIA ESWATINI SOUTHERN AFRICA

> COMESA's half-year progress report on the World Bank-financed Inclusive Digitalisation in Eastern and Southern Africa programme, a US$2.48 billion envelope, covers January to June 2026 in Angola, the DRC, Malawi, Zambia and Eswatini. The COMESA secretariat had spent 9% of its US$3.71 million 2026 budget by June, and moved its AI and regional digital inclusion consultancies from procurement to implementation.

Instruments and harmonisation

Standards

> HARMONISED INSURANCE SUPERVISION ASSESSMENT AND THE REGIONAL SUPERVISORY SOFTWARE

- **EAC regulators eye common insurance supervision rules** — Business Daily Africa, 20 September 2026

  Insurance regulators from six East African states adopted a harmonised assessment template built on about 25 insurance core principles, and agreed to run assessments against it and compare them in December. The same meeting approved regional guidelines on complaints handling and on comparable market data, and progressed a shared supervisory software for information exchange between the regulators.

AI

> HORN OF AFRICA REGIONAL ARTIFICIAL-INTELLIGENCE FRAMEWORK

- **IGAD Moves to Forge Regional AI Framework to Drive Integration, Development** — Fana Media Corporation S.C., 4 September 2026

  IGAD opened a two-day consultation in Addis Ababa to develop a common Horn of Africa framework and strategy for artificial intelligence. Its executive secretary put data sovereignty and accountability at the centre, set three priorities - directing investment where socioeconomic impact is greatest, closing gaps in infrastructure, policy and skills, and building regional synergies through harmonisation - and insisted the framework be owned by member states rather than treated as a secretariat project.

> REGIONAL HIGHER-EDUCATION QUALITY ASSURANCE UNDER AI

- **EA Universities Rethink Quality as AI Puts Degrees to a New Test** — KT Press, 7 September 2026 RWANDA

  Rwanda's Education Minister Joseph Nsengimana opened the 15th East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Network forum in Kigali on 7 September 2026, saying the region must rethink how it defines and assures quality in higher education as artificial intelligence changes teaching and work. The Inter-University Council for East Africa said a regional AI network has been launched.

> IGAD ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE

- **Communique of the 74th Extraordinary Session of the IGAD Council of Ministers** — IGAD, 15 September 2026

  Summarised under Regional collaboration.

> COMESA REGIONAL AI AND DIGITAL-INCLUSION STRATEGY

- **AI can drive economic growth across COMESA region - COMESA director** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026 SOUTHERN AFRICA

  A COMESA official told the regional AI validation meeting in Eswatini that AI could improve public services, agriculture, health and education across the region if member states invest in the skills, infrastructure and data it needs.

- **Eswatini hosts regional push for practical AI policies** — Times of Eswatini, 16 September 2026 ESWATINI AFRICA

  Eswatini is hosting a three-day COMESA meeting, opened on 16 September 2026, to validate a draft study on AI and emerging technologies. It precedes work on a regional AI strategy, model policy guidelines and a model regulatory framework under the World Bank-funded IDEA programme.

EAC REGIONAL AI AND PRODUCTIVITY STUDY

- **Chairperson of the EAC Heads of State Summit Lauds the Region's 6% Economic Growth, Calls on the Private Sector to Drive Shared Prosperity as East Africa CEO & Investment Forum Delivers US$3.95 Billion Investment Pipeline** — East African Business Council, 19 September 2026

  The first East Africa CEO and Investment Forum closed in Nairobi on 18 September 2026 with 95 pre-screened investment opportunities valued at nearly US$3.95bn, including digital infrastructure. The East African Business Council, the EAC Secretariat and the East African Development Bank launched a regional AI and productivity study, and EASTECO's cooperation with Hessen under the EAC AI Alliance was presented.

EAC AI FOUNDATIONAL MODULE

- **EAC Advances Regional AI Skills Initiative to Prepare East African Graduates for the Future of Work** — Inter-University Council for East Africa (IUCEA), 6 October 2026

  The East African Community, the Inter-University Council for East Africa and the East African Science and Technology Commission, with Germany, validated a draft EAC AI Foundational Module at a two-day workshop in Dar es Salaam, announced on 6 October 2026. The course aims to teach AI literacy to university students in all disciplines, and institutions in the EAC Regional AI Network may pilot it.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Cybersecurity

EACO FRAMEWORKS FOR RAPID CYBER-THREAT RESPONSE AMONG NATIONAL CERTS

- **East Africa Experts End Cybersecurity Summit in Juba** — Access Radio Yei News, 1 October 2026 SOUTH SUDAN

  An East African Communications Organisation working group, meeting in Juba, finalised frameworks for rapid cyber-threat response among national response teams. It also produced guidelines for users of digital financial services, child online protection measures and mobile data quality standards.

Data Exchange

REGIONAL ELECTRONIC CARGO TRACKING SYSTEM (RECTS)

- **Traders support revenue agency's multi-vendor cargo tracking system** — The Star (Kenya), 16 September 2026 KENYA

  Importers, exporters and logistics firms welcomed the Kenya Revenue Authority's decision to open the regional electronic cargo tracking system to private seal vendors. The Shippers Council of Eastern Africa expects competition to end seal shortages that have delayed transit cargo at Mombasa.

COMESA YELLOW CARD SCHEME ONLINE SALE AND DIGITAL VERIFICATION

- **Digital overhaul targets fraud in Sh3.5bn cross-border motor insurance market** — Business Daily (Nation Media Group), 13 October 2026 ZAMBIA SOUTHERN AFRICA

COMESA's Yellow Card cross-border motor insurance scheme is piloting online sale of cover in Zambia in 2026 and expanding phone-based certificate verification, now used in eight countries, through data sharing between members, Business Daily reported on 13 October 2026. The scheme issued more than 340,000 cards in 2025, worth about US$27 million (Sh3.5 billion) in premiums.

Digital Payments and Fintech

EAC PAYMENT AND SETTLEMENT SYSTEMS INTEGRATION (PSSI)

- **EAC Payment Systems Integration: Burundi Reaffirms Its Commitment to Regional Financial Integration** — Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Republic of Burundi, 24 September 2026 BURUNDI

  A ten-member East African Legislative Assembly delegation led by Saïd Kibeya held an oversight session in Bujumbura on 22 September 2026 on integrating East African Community payment and settlement systems. Burundi's EAC programme director general backed the regional Payment and Settlement Systems Initiative and named harmonised laws, supervision, cybersecurity and technical capacity as conditions for success.

AFRICA TRADE GATEWAY AGENCY AGREEMENT WITH THE EAST AFRICAN BUSINESS COUNCIL

- **Afreximbank and EABC Expand Digital Trade Access for East African Businesses through Africa Trade Gateway** — Afreximbank, 5 October 2026

  Afreximbank made the East African Business Council a trade corridor partner of its Africa Trade Gateway, to bring the region's firms onto its matchmaking, trade finance and payment services. The bank puts the gateway in more than 45 countries with 110 banks and 25,000 verified companies.

Sectoral management information systems

EAC CUSTOMS BOND (EACBOND DIGITAL REGIONAL CUSTOMS GUARANTEE)

- **Afreximbank issues a $29 million guarantee to scale EAC Customs Bond, easing movement of goods across East Africa** — African Export-Import Bank (Afreximbank), 22 September 2026

  Afreximbank issued a US$29m guarantee to BSMART Technology on 22 September 2026 to scale the EAC Customs Bond, a digital regional customs guarantee that removes the need to post paper bonds at each border. The bond was piloted from August 2025 and launched at the East African Community heads of state summit in March 2026.

- **Afreximbank — BSMART Technology, EAC Customs Bond guarantee, 2026** — African Export-Import Bank (Afreximbank), 22 September 2026

  Afreximbank issued a US$29 million guarantee to BSMART Technology Ltd, announced on 22 September 2026, to support the EAC Customs Bond, a digital platform that lets clearing agents obtain customs bonds online instead of lodging paper bonds at each border. Uganda, Rwanda and Burundi are named as onboarded. No tenor is stated.

EAC REGIONAL INFORMATION SHARING PLATFORM FOR PANDEMIC AND EPIDEMIC INTELLIGENCE

- **East African Community (EAC) Health Ministers Step Up Regional Action to Strengthen Health Security** — Africa Newsroom (APO Group), 8 October 2026

  East African Community health ministers, ending their 26th meeting in Arusha on 6 October 2026, advanced a regional platform for sharing pandemic and epidemic intelligence. They noted that all eight Partner States are onboarded and trained on the digital platform of the EAC pooled procurement mechanism, and called for a dashboard to track regional health decisions.

National statistics

USER SATISFACTION SURVEY ON REGIONAL STATISTICS

- **EAC Calls for Public Participation in Shaping Better Regional Statistics** — East African Community, 3 September 2026

  The East African Community Secretariat opened an online user satisfaction survey on EAC regional statistics on 3 September 2026, under the Eastern Africa Regional Statistics Program for Results. It asks statistics offices, central banks, businesses, researchers, media and others about the quality, timeliness and accessibility of the data. No closing date is given.

IGAD REGIONAL STRATEGY FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF STATISTICS II (2026-2030)

- **IGAD Member States adopt regional statistics strategy for 2026–2030 - IGAD** — IGAD, 28 September 2026

  The IGAD Statistics Committee adopted the second Regional Strategy for the Development of Statistics for 2026 to 2030 on 23 September 2026, endorsed by the statistics office heads of Djibouti, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan and Uganda. Its five pillars include modernisation and interoperability. The indicative cost is US$13.005 million across 69 interventions, and funding is not yet secured.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

EAC AI ALLIANCE AND AI-IN-EDUCATION HARMONISATION

- **East Africa CEO & Investment Forum 2026 calls for faster regional integration, investment and deal conversion** — East African Business Council (EABC), 17 September 2026

  The East African science and technology commission and the German state of Hessen launched a cooperation through the regional AI alliance at an investment forum in Nairobi, for skills development, innovation and business; no sum, instrument or duration was stated. The forum also launched a regional trade and investment climate report and an investment projects catalogue, and ran a digital economy, telecommunications and fintech track.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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